

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Court tosses suit against Md. judges

Trump sued state's bench over order to pause deportations

By Lea Skene and Sudhin Thanawala
Associated Press

BALTIMORE — A federal judge on Tuesday threw out the Trump administration's lawsuit against Maryland's entire federal bench in an emphatic ruling that underscored the extraordinary nature of the suit, slamming it as "potentially calamitous."

U.S. District Judge Thomas Cullen, who was nominated by President Donald Trump, also criticized the administration's attacks on the judiciary, highlighting in a footnote that White House officials in recent months had described judges as "rogue," "unhinged" and "crooked," among other epithets.

"Although some tension between the coordinate branches of government is a hallmark of our constitutional system, this concerted effort by the Executive to smear and impugn individual judges who rule against it is both unprecedented and unfortunate," he wrote.

The Trump administration filed a notice of appeal.

At issue in the lawsuit was an order by the chief judge of the Maryland district court that stopped the immediate deportation of migrants challenging their removals. The Justice Department said the automatic pause impeded the president's authority to enforce immigration laws, and it sought a court order blocking it.

Cullen said allowing the suit to continue "would run counter to overwhelming precedent, depart from longstanding constitutional tradition, and offend the rule of law."

"In their wisdom, the Constitution's framers joined three coordinate branches to establish a single sovereign," Cullen wrote. "That structure may occasionally engen-

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BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Eric Wilkins sits along South Michigan Avenue in Chicago's Roseland neighborhood on Tuesday, several blocks from where he was paralyzed in a 1999 shooting. He now works as an anti-violence organizer in the community and opposes the Trump administration sending National Guard troops to the city. Wilkins and other survivors called instead for the president to reinstate federal funding for gun violence prevention programs. "We've come up with some real solutions — that I work in — that we're using from the grassroots up," he said. **Chicagoland, Page 6**

As crime declines, many worry about Guard action

Experts say deployment amounts to political theater at best to 'recipe for disaster' at worst

By Caroline Kubzansky and Sam Charles
Chicago Tribune

Donald Trump has a habit of using Chicago when he wants to make a point about runaway urban violence, regardless of what is happening on the city's streets.

But when the president labels Chicago a "hellhole" as he did Tuesday and threatens again to "send in the Feds!" to boost his image as a law-and-order chief

executive, law enforcement experts and violence prevention leaders say sending the National Guard to Chicago would amount to a piece of political theater at best and "a recipe for disaster" at worst.

Crime here has swung high and low in the decade since Trump became a fixture on the national political scene. It spiked during the pandemic but is now dropping for the fourth consecutive year to levels not seen in more than a decade, mirroring

a national decline and cutting against the president's claims.

Through late August, Chicago had recorded 266 homicides in 2025, according to the Police Department. That's a 32% decline in killings from the same time period in 2024. Total shooting incidents are also down 36% citywide. Reports of robberies, batteries, burglaries and car thefts — "index crimes" used by CPD and the FBI to gauge criminal trends — are all down by double-digit percentages too.

CPD officers are making more arrests this year, records show. The average daily population of detainees in the Cook County Jail has returned to pre-pandemic levels, even as the SAFE-T Act was passed and implemented, eliminating the cash bail system.

Whatever the homicide rate has been, Trump has repeatedly claimed he has a magic wand that will fix the issue. In his first term, he said he would recruit

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Nevest Coleman, right, sits with his daughter Chanequa on Sunday in Chicago. Coleman spent 23 years behind bars before being exonerated in a 1994 sexual assault and murder. **BRIAN CASSELLA/TRIBUNE**

Despite DNA match, no new charges filed in 1994 slaying

Exonerated men's wrongful conviction lawsuits advance

By Gregory Royal Pratt
Chicago Tribune

More than seven years after DNA testing freed two men from prison, clearing them in the 1994 slaying of Antwinica Bridgeman, prosecutors have not filed new charges in the case despite a genetic match between semen found on her underwear and a man who lived nearby.

Last week, a federal judge's opinion on the two men's civil lawsuits against city and county

authorities revealed previously unreported details about the man, including his name — Clarence Neal — and that he had pleaded guilty to sexually assaulting a woman in 2001 as well as being "implicated in several other rapes."

Judge Martha Pacold's opinion also disclosed that the Cook County state's attorney's office sent investigators in 2017 to interview Neal. The opinion describes how Neal made several conflicting statements when they asked him if he had a sexual history with Bridgeman.

Nevest Coleman and Derrell "Darryl" Fulton, who spent 23 years behind bars after being

arrested in Bridgeman's slaying, are suing the Chicago Police Department, Cook County, several officers and a prosecutor. Attorneys for the defendants asked the judge to resolve most of the complaints in their favor, but Pacold ruled that the bulk of the cases can move forward toward trial.

Her opinion, reached in late March, was unsealed Wednesday, Aug. 20, with some material redacted.

While the suits continue to work their way through the civil court system, the lack of new criminal charges has drawn crit-

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Plant-based birth control to be tested on some city rats

Goal is to reduce population without harming urban wildlife

By Nara Schoenberg
Chicago Tribune

The latest weapon in Chicago's war against rats is plant-based, naturally flavored and nutritious.

It's a birth control pellet made with corn and peanuts, and a team of researchers and volunteers will be serving it to discerning rats in a four-block area of Lincoln Park for a year.

The aim is to reduce the rat population without harming urban wildlife, including owls and hawks, which can die after eating poisoned rodents.

The study was sparked by the high-profile deaths of three beloved Lincoln Park owls — mom, dad and owlet — who made their



A rat in an alley in the 1900 block of North Halsted Street on Aug. 12 in Chicago. **ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

home near North Pond and died in rapid succession last April and May. The deaths were all linked to rat poison, which causes internal bleeding.

"We just realized we had to do something," said Judy Pollock, former president of the Chicago

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INSIDE

Reader finds new life with new buyer

Publication is being acquired by Noisy Creek, a media company that has bought other alternative weeklies. **Business**

Bears make some big roster decisions

The Bears have set their initial 53-man roster. Take a look at who made the cut — and who didn't. **Chicago Sports**

TODAY'S WEATHER



High 77 Low 62

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 14

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